ISSUE
No
XIII

AUGUST 27, 2026

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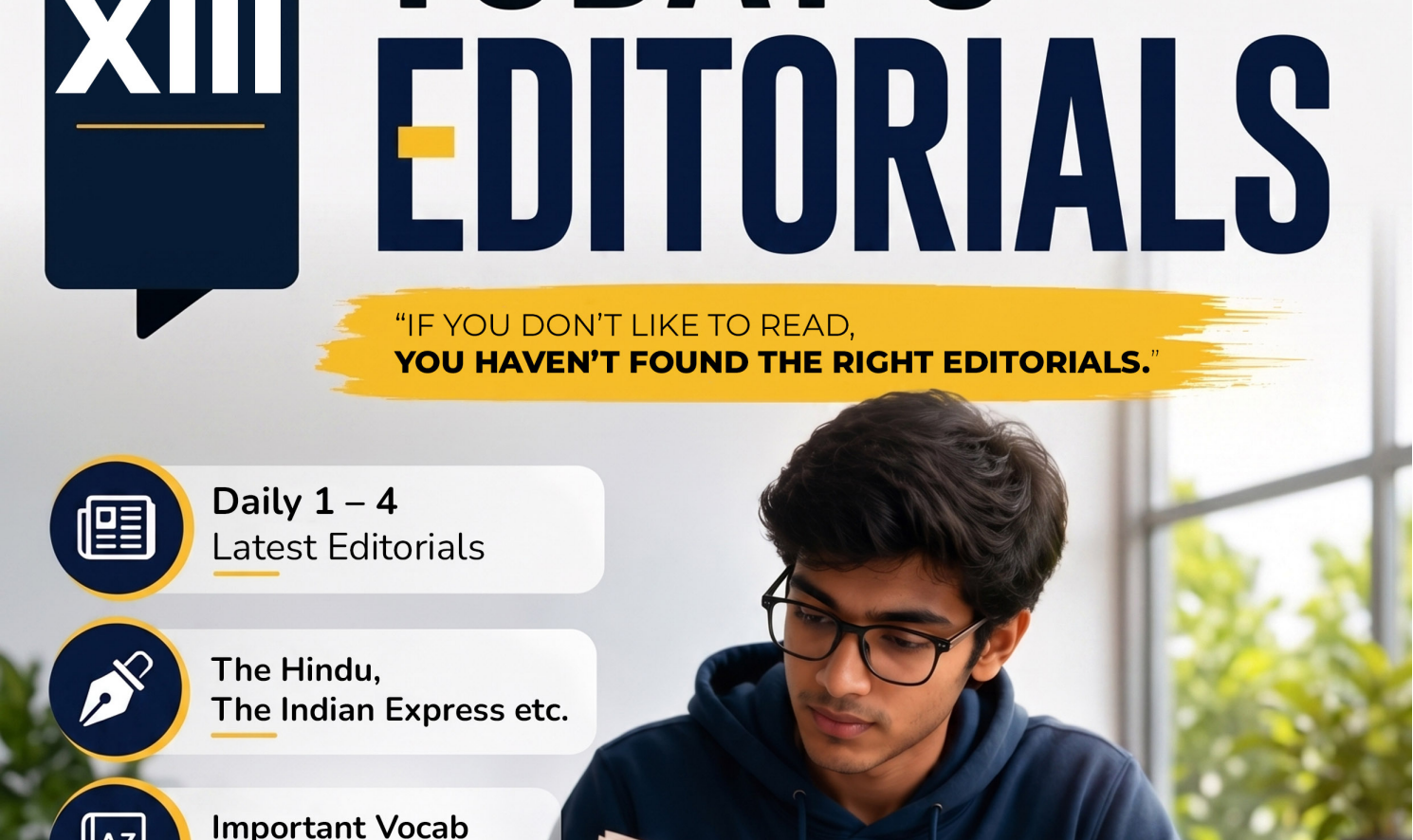

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ISSUE
No
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AUGUST 27, 2026

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>
> -SARAH J. MAAS

STAY INFORMED.
STAT AHEAD.
SUCCED.

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THE HINDU · GEOPOLITICS

Drawing lines: On the India-China 25th Special Representatives' talks

India and China advance border talks to secure stability, requiring public transparency for lasting trust.

August 27, 2026 · 2 min read · DAILY EDITORIAL READER

Following Tuesday's talks between the Special Representatives (SRs) on the boundary question, India and China have agreed to **substantial**[1] outcomes on managing the disputed border. According to an eight-point **consensus**[2] released on Wednesday, both countries have agreed to advance discussions on "an early and **substantial**[1] harvest of boundary **delimitation**[3]". They have agreed to hold next month a meeting of an expert-level mechanism on trans-border rivers and to maintain communication on sharing hydrological data, which India has been **pushing for**[4]. Two additional meeting points to hold talks between top military commanders will be set up, along with two new channels of hotlines in the Eastern and Middle Sectors. National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and China's Foreign Minister Wang Yi **reaffirmed**[5] the efforts taken over the past two years to keep the peace along the Line of Actual Control, and **committed to**[6] continuing the on-going **normalisation**[7] in relations. That the NSA's visit to Beijing took place before India hosts the BRICS Summit, on September 12, **underlined**[8] both sides' **keenness**[9] to continue with this process of **re-engagement**[10], with the expected visit of Chinese President Xi Jinping after a gap of seven years. An October 2024 meeting between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Mr. Xi **kickstarted**[11] this **calibrated**[12] effort towards normalcy, and a 2025 meeting in Tianjin helped continue the **momentum**[13]. It is **apparent**[14] that both sides see continued engagement at the highest level as key to **sustaining**[15] this process of **normalisation**[7].

The dual tracks of the SR meetings and the Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on border affairs, a body **comprising**[16] diplomats and military officials, have worked well towards keeping the borders generally stable over the past two years. The latest outcomes will certainly help in keeping the peace. Less clear is how both sides intend to take up the task of border **delimitation**[3]. Neither side has explained which parts of the border they plan to delimit, or whether they are reconsidering the 2005 agreement on Political Parameters and Guiding Principles, under which the SRs were **tasked with**[17] first agreeing a framework to settle the boundary. While both sides in Beijing **reaffirmed**[5] the 2005 agreement, Article 10 of its text notes that it is only on the basis of the framework that both sides can **delineate**[18] the boundary. **Tangible**[19] progress on the border dispute must certainly be welcomed. However, agreements made without **public visibility**[20], **notwithstanding**[21] their **merit**[22], may invite suspicion. As India and China continue negotiating their long-running boundary question, it is **imperative**[23] that they bring their publics along.

Source: The Hindu · Date: 2026-08-27

★ VOCABULARY 101

#	Word	Meaning
1	**Substantial** (Adjective)	significant • ठोस / महत्वपूर्ण
2	**Consensus** (Noun)	agreement • आम सहमति
3	**Delimitation** (Noun)	boundary-marking • सीमांकन
4	**Pushing for** (Phrasal verb)	demanding • दबाव बनाना / मांग करना
5	**Reaffirmed** (Verb)	reconfirmed • फिर से पुष्टि की
6	**Committed to** (Prepositional verb)	dedicated to • वचनबद्ध / प्रतिबद्ध
7	**Normalisation** (Noun)	regularisation • सामान्यीकरण
8	**Underlined** (Verb)	highlighted • रेखांकित किया / बल दिया
9	**Keenness** (Noun)	eagerness • उत्सुकता
10	**Re-engagement** (Noun)	reconnecting • फिर से जुड़ना
11	**Kickstarted** (Phrasal verb)	initiated • शुरुआत की
12	**Calibrated** (Adjective)	measured • नपा-तुला / परिष्कृत
13	**Momentum** (Noun)	impetus • गति / रफ़्तार
14	**Apparent** (Adjective)	evident • स्पष्ट / प्रत्यक्ष
15	**Sustaining** (Verb)	maintaining • बनाए रखना
16	**Comprising** (Verb)	consisting of • शामिल होना / बना होना
17	**Tasked with** (Prepositional verb)	assigned to • कार्य सौंपा गया
18	**Delineate** (Verb)	outline • वर्णन करना / रेखांकित करना
19	**Tangible** (Adjective)	concrete • वास्तविक / ठोस
20	**Public visibility** (Noun phrase)	transparency • सार्वजनिक पारदर्शिता
21	**Notwithstanding** (Preposition)	despite • के बावजूद
22	**Merit** (Noun)	worth • योग्यता / गुण
23	**Imperative** (Adjective)	essential • अति आवश्यक
24	**Bring along** (Phrasal verb)	involve • साथ लेकर चलना

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EDITORIAL ANALYSIS & VOCABULARY LAB

ARTICLE: Drawing lines: On the India-China 25th Special Representatives' talks

THE HINDU · GEOPOLITICS

EDITORIAL STANCE

CAUTIOUSLY OPTIMISTIC

"hopeful yet careful"

EXECUTIVE PERSPECTIVE

The author adopts a cautiously optimistic tone to evaluate recent diplomatic discussions between India and China regarding border management. While welcoming tangible achievements such as high-level dialogues and new military communication channels, the author stresses that long-term stability requires clear delimitation parameters. Ultimately, the piece supports continued engagement while urging both governments to maintain public transparency to avoid suspicion.

EDITORIAL VOCABULARY · 11 WORDS

#	Word	Meaning	Memory Hook	Synonyms	Antonyms
01	**Substantial** ADJECTIVE POSITIVE	ठोस / महत्वपूर्ण Of considerable importance, size, value, or worth.	Substantial sounds like 'substance' — having real substance, weight, or worth.	• considerable • significant • sizeable	• insignificant • slight • negligible
02	**Reaffirmed** VERB POSITIVE	फिर से पुष्टि की Stated or asserted again strongly and formally.	Re (again) + Affirm (confirm firmly) = reasserting a commitment.	• reasserted • ratified • confirmed	• denied • retracted • repudiated
03	**Normalisation** NOUN POSITIVE	सामान्यीकरण The process of bringing relations or conditions back to a regular, peaceful state.	Process of bringing abnormal or tense diplomatic ties back to normal.	• regularisation • reconciliation • stabilisation	• deterioration • escalation • disruption
04	**Underlined** VERB NEUTRAL	रेखांकित किया / बल दिया Emphasised or drew special attention to a fact or situation.	Drawing a physical line under text to show its crucial importance.	• emphasised • accentuated • highlighted	• downplayed • glossed over • ignored
05	**Keenness** NOUN POSITIVE	उत्सुकता The quality of being eager, enthusiastic, or determined.	Keen edge = sharp enthusiasm and intense readiness to act.	• eagerness • enthusiasm • ardour	• apathy • indifference • reluctance
06	**Calibrated** ADJECTIVE NEUTRAL	नपा-तुला / परिष्कृत Carefully assessed, adjusted, or planned to achieve a precise effect.	Calibrated scales give exact, carefully calculated weight.	• calculated • measured • fine-tuned	• unplanned • haphazard • arbitrary
07	**Momentum** NOUN POSITIVE	गति / रफ़्तार The driving force or acceleration gained by the development of a process.	Physics term: mass in motion gaining speed as it proceeds.	• impetus • thrust • drive	• stagnation • stoppage • inertia
08	**Apparent** ADJECTIVE NEUTRAL	स्पष्ट / प्रत्यक्ष Clearly visible or understood; obvious to the mind or eye.	Apparent -> appears clearly to anyone who looks.	• evident • obvious • manifest	• obscure • hidden • unclear
09	**Sustaining** VERB POSITIVE	बनाए रखना Maintaining, supporting, or enduring an action or process over time.	Sustain = stand under pressure over a long duration without giving up.	• maintaining • upholding • preserving	• undermining • disrupting • relinquishing
10	**Tangible** ADJECTIVE POSITIVE	वास्तविक / ठोस Perceptible by touch; clear, definite, and real.	Tangible -> touchable; real enough to be seen and felt, not theoretical.	• palpable • concrete • perceptible	• intangible • abstract • illusory
11	**Merit** NOUN POSITIVE	योग्यता / गुण The quality of being particularly good, worthy, or deserving of praise.	Merit badges are awarded solely for intrinsic value and good deeds.	• worth • value • excellence	• demerit • worthlessness • flaw

VOCAB LAB CONTINUED · DRAWING LINES: ON THE INDIA-CHINA 25TH SPECIAL REPRESENTATIVES' TALKS · PART 02

ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS · 5 TERMS

#	Word	Meaning	Memory Hook	Synonyms	Antonyms
01	**Consensus** NOUN	आम सहमति A general agreement shared by a group of people or nations.	Con + Sense + us = common sense agreed upon by all of us.	• unanimity • concord • accord	• discord • disagreement • dissent
02	**Delimitation** NOUN	सीमांकन The action of officially fixing the boundary or limits of an area.	De-LIMIT-ation = the act of fixing limits or boundaries.	• demarcation • bounding • definition	• expansion • unbounding • indefiniteness
03	**Delineate** VERB	वर्णन करना / रेखांकित करना Describe, portray, or mark the exact position of a boundary or outline.	De-LINE-ate = draw precise lines to map or describe something.	• demarcate • outline • depict	• distort • confuse • muddle
04	**Notwithstanding** PREPOSITION	के बावजूद In spite of; despite the existence of something.	Not + standing + against = regardless of any existing obstacle.	• despite • regardless of • heedless of	• because of • owing to • due to
05	**Imperative** ADJECTIVE	अति आवश्यक Of vital importance; crucial, urgent, or mandatory.	Imperial command = an absolute necessity that must be followed immediately.	• crucial • vital • essential	• optional • unnecessary • trivial

READ NEXT EDITORIAL • PAGE 06
Grounded: On Tamil Nadu's Parandur airport project →

THE HINDU · INFRASTRUCTURE POLICY & POLITICS

Grounded: On Tamil Nadu's Parandur airport project

Scrapping the Parandur airport project risks harming Tamil Nadu's long-term infrastructure and economic growth goals.

August 27, 2026 · 2 min read · DAILY EDITORIAL READER

The Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK)-led government, in **dropping**[1] the ₹27,400-crore **greenfield**[2] airport project at Parandur near Chennai, appears to have considered the opposition to the project without weighing the consequences. The decision follows an electoral promise made by Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, who had visited the protesters in January 2025 to express his **solidarity**[3]. The government says the move is aimed at protecting the interests of farmers and local residents. It has also cited the presence of waterbodies and has alleged commercial motives behind the site selection under the previous DMK government. **Notwithstanding**[4] these official reasons, all valid to varying degrees, it became clear from the day Mr. Vijay became Chief Minister, on May 10, 2026, that the decision was merely a **formality**[5]. In fact, much before the announcement, on August 24, work on the project had **come to a halt**[6]. However, the move is likely to have **adverse**[7] consequences for Tamil Nadu. The move risks creating a general **perception**[8] that Tamil Nadu is unstable in its infrastructure policy, which the TVK government should have avoided, given its goal of making the State a $1.5 trillion economy by 2036.

While Mr. Vijay has spoken of identifying a new airport site, his proposal for a Terminal 5 at the existing airport is necessary and welcome. However, it is common knowledge that a **greenfield**[2] airport will take years to **materialise**[9], even with **unwavering**[10] government attention — the idea for a second airport had been **under consideration**[11] for over 25 years. At one stage, the Union government had wanted it to be developed on a build, operate and transfer mode. Unfortunately, the project was caught in the game of political **one-upmanship**[12] between the two Dravidian majors. Meanwhile, Bengaluru and Hyderabad have had new second airports since 2008, despite **regime**[18] changes. Passenger traffic here has grown **at Tamil Nadu's expense**[13] — at an annual average rate of 10% during 2016-26 compared with 2.4% in Chennai. Parandur received the Union government's final nod in July 2024, after much **groundwork**[14]. When the State government is not the ultimate authority in airport site selection, it would not be **appropriate to**[15] **attribute motives to**[16] the DMK. Land for any mega project has always faced landowner **resistance**[17] and the TVK **regime**[18] may experience this while identifying a new site. No development project can take place without **disturbing**[19] the environment and certain sections of society. Even Amsterdam's busy Schiphol airport sits over an area that was once a lake. At the existing airport in Chennai, a runway was affected by the severe floods in 2015. What policymakers should **bear in mind**[20] is the need to balance development and climate change challenges. Chennai needs more runways, not just new terminals.

Source: The Hindu · Date: 2026-08-27

★ VOCABULARY 101

#	Word	Meaning
1	**dropping** (Verb)	abandoning • रद्द करना / छोड़ना
2	**greenfield** (Adjective)	undeveloped • नया और अप्रयुक्त प्रोजेक्ट
3	**solidarity** (Noun)	unity • एकजुटता
4	**Notwithstanding** (Preposition)	despite • के बावजूद
5	**formality** (Noun)	routine • औपचारिकता
6	**come to a halt** (Verb)	stop • ठप पड़ना
7	**adverse** (Adjective)	harmful • प्रतिकूल / हानिकारक
8	**perception** (Noun)	belief • धारणा
9	**materialise** (Verb)	happen • साकार होना
10	**unwavering** (Adjective)	steady • अडिग / स्थिर
11	**under consideration** (Prepositional phrase)	being discussed • विचाराधीन
12	**one-upmanship** (Noun)	rivalry • बाज़ी मारने की होड़
13	**at Tamil Nadu's expense** (Prepositional phrase)	at the cost of • तमिलनाडु की कीमत पर
14	**groundwork** (Noun)	preparation • बुनियादी काम / तैयारी
15	**appropriate to** (Prepositional phrase)	suitable for • के लिए उचित
16	**attribute motives to** (Verb phrase)	blame intentions on • मंशा या नीयत पर सवाल उठाना
17	**resistance** (Noun)	opposition • विरोध / प्रतिरोध
18	**regime** (Noun)	government • शासन / सरकार
19	**disturbing** (Verb)	disrupting • बाधा डालना / अशांत करना
20	**bear in mind** (Verb phrase)	remember • ध्यान में रखना

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ARTICLE: Grounded: On Tamil Nadu's Parandur airport project

THE HINDU · INFRASTRUCTURE POLICY & POLITICS

EDITORIAL STANCE

CRITICAL

"pointing out faults"

EXECUTIVE PERSPECTIVE

The author adopts a critical tone regarding the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam government's decision to scrap the Parandur airport project without evaluating long-term consequences. The piece highlights that fulfilling electoral promises for short-term political gains creates policy instability and hurts Tamil Nadu's economic expansion compared to neighboring states. Ultimately, the author emphasizes that policymakers must strike a pragmatic balance between environmental sustainability and necessary infrastructure development.

EDITORIAL VOCABULARY · 9 WORDS

#	Word	Meaning	Memory Hook	Synonyms	Antonyms
01	**solidarity** NOUN POSITIVE	एकजुटता Mutual support and agreement among individuals or groups with a common interest.	Solid + unity = standing together so firmly that your combined support is solid.	• unity • unanimity • cohesion	• discord • division • antagonism
02	**formality** NOUN NEUTRAL	औपचारिकता An action done merely to comply with official rules, with an outcome already certain.	Formal procedure — doing something just to follow official rules when the result is predetermined.	• matter of routine • technicality • ritual	• informality • spontaneity • choice
03	**adverse** ADJECTIVE NEGATIVE	प्रतिकूल / हानिकारक Preventing success or development; harmful, unfavourable, or hostile.	Adverse sounds like adversary (an enemy) — causing hostile or harmful effects.	• unfavourable • detrimental • disadvantageous	• favourable • beneficial • advantageous
04	**perception** NOUN NEUTRAL	धारणा The way in which something is regarded, understood, or interpreted by the public.	Percept -> perceive -> the way an audience perceives or views a policy.	• impression • viewpoint • understanding	• misunderstanding • ignorance • reality
05	**materialise** VERB NEUTRAL	साकार होना To become actual fact, take shape, or come into real existence.	Material = tangible object; materialise means becoming actual physical reality.	• actualise • manifest • come to fruition	• vanish • fail • evaporate
06	**unwavering** ADJECTIVE POSITIVE	अडिग / स्थिर Steady, firm, and resolute; not faltering or changing in determination.	Un + wavering (waving back and forth); not shaking or hesitating at all.	• steadfast • resolute • unfaltering	• faltering • wavering • irresolute
07	**resistance** NOUN NEUTRAL	विरोध / प्रतिरोध Refusal to accept or comply with something; active opposition or pushback.	Resisting or pushing back against an unwanted force or policy.	• opposition • defiance • pushback	• acceptance • compliance • submission
08	**regime** NOUN NEUTRAL	शासन / सरकार A government or a particular system of administration.	Think of reign/regiment — a specific ruling system or government in power.	• administration • government • rule	• anarchy • chaos • lawlessness
09	**disturbing** VERB NEGATIVE	बाधा डालना / अशांत करना Disrupting or interfering with the normal state, order, or ecological equilibrium.	Disturbing peace or ecology — interfering with the normal balance of things.	• disrupting • upsetting • interfering with	• preserving • maintaining • protecting

VOCAB LAB CONTINUED · GROUNDED: ON TAMIL NADU'S PARANDUR AIRPORT PROJECT · PART 02

ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS · 2 TERMS

#	Word	Meaning	Memory Hook	Synonyms	Antonyms
01	**greenfield** ADJECTIVE	नया और अप्रयुक्त प्रोजेक्ट Denoting a project planned or constructed on previously undeveloped land from scratch.	Green field = a fresh grassy field where nothing has been built yet; building from scratch.	• newly planned • undeveloped • virgin	• brownfield • redeveloped • existing
02	**groundwork** NOUN	बुनियादी काम / तैयारी Preliminary work or preparation undertaken to establish a foundation for a project.	Work done on the ground before erecting a high-rise building.	• preparations • preliminaries • foundation	• conclusion • aftermath • finish

READ NEXT EDITORIAL • PAGE 09
Devendra Fadnavis government's anti-conversion law, language diktats shrink Mumbai →

THE INDIAN EXPRESS · GOVERNANCE & CIVIL LIBERTIES

Devendra Fadnavis government's anti-conversion law, language diktats shrink Mumbai

Divisive identity politics and regressive social diktats threaten to derail Mumbai's progressive economic momentum.

August 27, 2026 · 2 min read · DAILY EDITORIAL READER

Two stories are **unfolding**[1] in Mumbai **on the watch of**[2] the Devendra Fadnavis government. Since his first term in office, the Chief Minister has become the face of a welcome governance and infrastructure-building push in the country's financial capital. The other story is **disquieting**[3] by itself, and also potentially **undermines**[4] the gains of the first — take the Maharashtra Freedom of Religion Act, which **comes into force**[5] this week. Christian pastors across the Mumbai Metropolitan area have asked **congregants**[6] to submit a "self-declaration" that they attend prayer meetings of their own **volition**[7] — this is because the Act comes against the **backdrop of**[8] harassment of **congregants**[6] and disruption of meetings by groups like Bajrang Dal and VHP, and in the **aftermath**[9], the police's one-sided action.

Over the last month, seven out of the nine FIRs registered have been against those who organised prayers — and two against the Bajrang Dal. The Act is **draconian**[10], and **flies in the face of**[11] the Supreme Court ruling in Rev Stainislaus v State of Madhya Pradesh (1977), which laid down the **parameters**[12] for the constitutionality of laws against conversion. The recent **spate of**[13] anti-conversion laws in several states reverse the **burden of proof**[14]. The Maharashtra law prescribes harsh punishments, asks for **intimation**[15] to the district magistrate in advance and allows parents, siblings and relatives, not just the individuals involved, to complain to the police. In this context, the "self-declaration" is a form of insurance against a law that is all too **vulnerable to**[16] misuse.

Fadnavis rose to **prominence**[17] as a young leader in a state where politics and governance are often overshadowed by **nativism**[18] and overtaken by **parochialism**[19]. He seemed to acknowledge that ease of doing business requires a more governance-oriented approach by a state with a light touch. But the recent push to force auto and taxi drivers in Mumbai to learn Marathi is another symptom of the **backsliding**[20]. It sends out the message that the government is focusing more on a narrow and performative politics of identity even as it **takes a toll on**[21] the city's economic activity, and **undermines**[4] citizens' right to work and mobility. The fact that members of a minority community that is part of the **fabric of**[22] Mumbai feel the need to sign **pre-emptive**[23] declarations is a stain on the Constitution's promise of **freedom of conscience**[24] and the right to practice and propagate religious belief. It is now for the government and ruling party to ensure that these fears are **allayed**[25]. The financial capital of the country cannot flourish if it tries to dictate the language the people speak and what they believe.

Source: The Indian Express · Date: 2026-08-27

★ VOCABULARY 101

#	Word	Meaning
1	**unfolding** (Verb)	developing • क्रमशः सामने आना / घटित होना
2	**on the watch of** (Prepositional phrase)	under the tenure of • की देखरेख या शासनकाल में
3	**disquieting** (Adjective)	worrying • अशांत करने वाला / चिंताजनक
4	**undermines** (Verb)	weakens • कमज़ोर करना / क्षति पहुँचाना
5	**comes into force** (Verb phrase)	takes effect • लागू होना / प्रभाव में आना
6	**congregants** (Noun)	worshippers • धार्मिक सभा में एकत्र श्रद्धालु
7	**volition** (Noun)	free will • स्वेच्छा / अपनी मर्ज़ी
8	**backdrop of** (Prepositional phrase)	context of • की पृष्ठभूमि में
9	**aftermath** (Noun)	consequences • दुष्परिणाम / उत्तर प्रभाव
10	**draconian** (Adjective)	harsh • अति कठोर / दमनकारी
11	**flies in the face of** (Idiom)	contradicts • सीधे तौर पर विरोध करना या उल्टे चलना
12	**parameters** (Noun)	limits • दायरा / सीमाएं
13	**spate of** (Noun phrase)	wave of • सिलसिला / अचानक आई बाढ़ जैसी संख्या
14	**burden of proof** (Noun phrase)	onus probandi • सबूत पेश करने की ज़िम्मेदारी
15	**intimation** (Noun)	prior notice • पूर्व सूचना / इत्तिला
16	**vulnerable to** (Adjective phrase)	exposed to • के प्रति असुरक्षित / आसानी से चपेट में आने वाला
17	**prominence** (Noun)	fame • प्रसिद्धि / प्रमुखता
18	**nativism** (Noun)	anti-migrant bias • मूलनिवासी पक्षपात / भूमिपुत्र की संकीर्ण नीति
19	**parochialism** (Noun)	narrow-mindedness • संकीर्णता / कूपमंडूकता
20	**backsliding** (Noun)	relapse • पतन / पुरानी बुरी स्थिति में लौटना
21	**takes a toll on** (Idiom)	damages • बुरा असर डालना / भारी नुकसान पहुँचाना
22	**fabric of** (Noun phrase)	structure of • का मूलभूत ढांचा या स्वरूप
23	**pre-emptive** (Adjective)	preventive • पूर्वाह्न / पहले ही बचाव के रूप में किया गया
24	**freedom of conscience** (Noun phrase)	moral liberty • अंतःकरण की स्वतंत्रता
25	**allayed** (Verb)	calmed • शांत करना / भय दूर करना

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EDITORIAL ANALYSIS & VOCABULARY LAB

ARTICLE: Devendra Fadnavis government's anti-conversion law, language diktats ...

THE INDIAN EXPRESS · GOVERNANCE & CIVIL LIBERTIES

EDITORIAL STANCE

CRITICAL

"expressing strong disapproval"

EXECUTIVE PERSPECTIVE

The author adopts a critical tone to censure the Maharashtra state administration over its newly enacted anti-conversion law and restrictive linguistic mandates. The piece argues that yielding to parochial identity politics threatens Mumbai's cosmopolitan fabric and undermines fundamental constitutional safeguards. Ultimately, the editorial concludes that the government must urgently allay minority apprehensions to preserve the city's economic vitality and pluralism.

EDITORIAL VOCABULARY · 12 WORDS

#	Word	Meaning	Memory Hook	Synonyms	Antonyms
01	**unfolding** VERB NEUTRAL	क्रमशः सामने आना / घटित होना Gradually developing or revealing itself over time.	Un + fold: when you unfold a map or paper, events open up step by step.	• transpiring • emerging • evolving	• halting • receding • stagnating
02	**disquieting** ADJECTIVE NEGATIVE	अशांत करने वाला / चिंताजनक Inducing feelings of anxiety, unease, or worry.	Dis + quiet: taking away the quietness or peace of mind.	• unsettling • perturbing • disturbing	• reassuring • comforting • soothing
03	**undermines** VERB NEGATIVE	कमज़ोर करना / क्षति पहुँचाना Subversively or gradually weakening and eroding base strength or authority.	Under + mine: digging a mine under a building causes its base to weaken and collapse.	• subverts • sabotages • compromises	• bolsters • reinforces • strengthens
04	**volition** NOUN POSITIVE	स्वेच्छा / अपनी मर्ज़ी The faculty or power of using one's own will to make conscious choices.	Sounds like voluntary — acting purely out of your own choice.	• free will • discretion • autonomy	• coercion • compulsion • duress
05	**aftermath** NOUN NEGATIVE	दुष्परिणाम / उत्तर प्रभाव The unpleasant consequences or repercussions following a disruptive event.	After the storm has passed, doing the math on the damages left behind.	• repercussions • fallout • sequel	• precursor • antecedent • origin
06	**draconian** ADJECTIVE NEGATIVE	अति कठोर / दमनकारी Exceedingly harsh, cruel, or excessively rigorous.	Derived from Draco, the ancient Athenian lawgiver who prescribed death for minor offences.	• oppressive • stringent • authoritarian	• lenient • humane • tolerant
07	**parameters** NOUN NEUTRAL	दायरा / सीमाएं A numerical or other measurable factor forming a set of defining boundaries.	Perimeter marks the outer boundary; parameters define permissible boundaries.	• framework • boundaries • specifications	• boundlessness • indeterminacy
08	**intimation** NOUN NEUTRAL	पूर्व सूचना / इत्तिला An official indication, notification, or formal declaration in advance.	To intimate someone means to make known formally or subtly beforehand.	• notification • announcement • declaration	• concealment • withholding • secrecy
09	**prominence** NOUN POSITIVE	प्रसिद्धि / प्रमुखता The state of being widely known, distinguished, or important.	Prominent peaks stand tall and visible above the rest.	• eminence • pre-eminence • distinction	• obscurity • insignificance • anonymity
10	**backsliding** NOUN NEGATIVE	पतन / पुरानी बुरी स्थिति में लौटना Relapsing into bad ways, regressive practices, or poorer standards.	Sliding backwards instead of progressing forwards.	• retrogradation • regression • recidivism	• advancement • improvement • progression
11	**pre-emptive** ADJECTIVE NEUTRAL	पूर्वाह्न / पहले ही बचाव के रूप में किया गया Intended to forestall or deter an anticipated, usually unpleasant, situation.	Pre (before) + empty: acting beforehand to prevent or defuse a future threat.	• proactive • forestalling • precautionary	• reactive • belated • responsive
12	**allayed** VERB POSITIVE	शांत करना / भय दूर करना Diminished or put to rest fear, suspicion, or anxiety.	Allay sounds like 'all-okay' — assuring everyone that all is fine to diminish fear.	• assuaged • mitigated • mollified	• exacerbated • inflamed • intensified

VOCAB LAB CONTINUED · DEVENDRA FADNAVIS GOVERNMENT'S ANTI-CONVERSION LAW, LANGUAGE DIKTATS SHRINK MUMBAI · PART 02

ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS · 4 TERMS

#	Word	Meaning	Memory Hook	Synonyms	Antonyms
01	**congregants** NOUN	धार्मिक सभा में एकत्र श्रद्धालु Members of a group gathered together for religious worship.	Congregation means a gathering; congregants are the people who gather to pray.	• parishioners • worshippers • devotees	• non-believers • outsiders • seceders
02	**nativism** NOUN	मूलनिवासी पक्षपात / भूमिपुत्र की संकीर्ण नीति A political policy promoting the interests of native inhabitants over those of immigrants.	Native + ism: the political ideology of prioritising only native-born inhabitants.	• xenophobia • chauvinism • insularity	• cosmopolitanism • multiculturalism • internationalism
03	**parochialism** NOUN	संकीर्णता / कूपमंडूकता A narrow or limited outlook that fails to consider wider, cosmopolitan contexts.	Parish = a small local church district. Parochial = restricted only to your small local area.	• provincialism • illiberality • sectarianism	• broad-mindedness • cosmopolitanism • openness
04	**freedom of conscience** NOUN PHRASE	अंतःकरण की स्वतंत्रता The constitutional freedom of an individual to hold or consider facts and moral viewpoints independently.	Conscience is your inner moral voice; freedom of conscience is the liberty to heed it.	• liberty of thought • freedom of worship • moral autonomy	• indoctrination • dogmatism • thought control

READ NEXT EDITORIAL • PAGE 12
A death at IIT-Delhi and the many invisible struggles on campus →

THE INDIAN EXPRESS · HIGHER EDUCATION & MENTAL HEALTH

A death at IIT-Delhi and the many invisible struggles on campus

Premier academic institutions must dismantle hyper-competitive cultures to safeguard student mental health and well-being.

August 27, 2026 · 2 min read · DAILY EDITORIAL READER

By all accounts[1], Rishikesh Kumar from Bihar was a bright young man who had made it to IIT-Delhi **in pursuit of**[2] a dream. Physics fascinated him; poetry offered another outlet for his creativity. Yet beneath the promise and ambition was a young man struggling with mental-health challenges. His death, allegedly by suicide on August 22, has once again brought into focus the helplessness that can **lurk**[3] beneath the surface of hyper-competitive institutions. Kumar's death was the eighth such incident at the campus since 2023.

Over the last five years, the IITs have been **proactive**[4] in acknowledging that access does not always **translate into**[5] comfort and belonging. Measures such as **supernumerary**[6] quotas for women and athletes in undergraduate courses to enhance diversity, and the creation of posts such as the dean of student well-being, recognise that the pressures within elite campuses are shaped as much by the **collision**[7] between identity and expectation as by an intensely competitive environment. The pressure does not end with securing a place at an IIT; for many, it simply changes form — from the struggle to get in, to the struggle to **keep up**[8] and **fit in**[9]. A 2023-24 IIT-Delhi committee described a culture of post-coaching **burnout**[10], and **alienation**[11] among **marginalised**[12] and first-generation students. It makes every setback — from a failed relationship to an inadequate score — feel unusually **consequential**[13].

Following protests, IIT-Delhi has set up a committee to conduct a **probe**[14] into Kumar's death. But the questions go beyond the campus. Far too often, mental health is looked at **through the prism of**[15] individual histories. But for young people who have demonstrated remarkable **fortitude**[16] in coping with pressures along their journey to some of the country's **premier**[17] institutions, what explains their inability to deal with what follows? It is this **contradiction**[18] that parents and educators must address with urgency. How can environments be built where ambition and well-being **go hand in hand**[19], where counselling creates safe spaces, where empathy shows youngsters how to **regulate**[20] their response to life's **vagaries**[21]? The road ahead must involve a rethinking of the culture of competition itself, so that institutions do not merely produce high achievers, but are home to **thriving**[22] young people.

Source: The Indian Express · Date: 2026-08-27

★ VOCABULARY 101

#	Word	Meaning
1	**By all accounts** (Idiom)	according to everyone • प्राप्त जानकारी या वृत्तांत के अनुसार
2	**in pursuit of** (Prepositional phrase)	seeking • की तलाश में / पाने के प्रयास में
3	**lurk** (Verb)	hide • घात लगाकर छिपे रहना / अनदेखा मौजूद होना
4	**proactive** (Adjective)	taking initiative • सक्रिय / अग्रसक्रिय
5	**translate into** (Phrasal verb)	result in • में परिवर्तित होना / परिणत होना
6	**supernumerary** (Adjective)	extra • अधिसंख्य / आवश्यकता या सामान्य संख्या से अधिक
7	**collision** (Noun)	clash • टकराव / मतभेद
8	**keep up** (Phrasal verb)	match pace • बराबरी बनाए रखना / साथ-साथ चलना
9	**fit in** (Phrasal verb)	belong • समायोजित होना / घुल-मिल जाना
10	**burnout** (Noun)	exhaustion • अत्यधिक मानसिक या शारीरिक थकान
11	**alienation** (Noun)	isolation • अलगाव / बेगानापन
12	**marginalised** (Adjective)	disadvantaged • हाशिए पर धकेले गए
13	**consequential** (Adjective)	momentous • अत्यधिक महत्वपूर्ण / गम्भीर परिणाम वाला
14	**probe** (Noun)	investigation • गहन जांच / अन्वेषण
15	**through the prism of** (Idiom)	from the viewpoint of • के नज़रिए या दृष्टिकोण से
16	**fortitude** (Noun)	courage • धैर्य / मानसिक दृढ़ता
17	**premier** (Adjective)	top-ranking • अग्रणी / प्रमुख
18	**contradiction** (Noun)	paradox • विरोधाभास
19	**go hand in hand** (Idiom)	exist together • साथ-साथ चलना / अविभाज्य होना
20	**regulate** (Verb)	control • नियंत्रित या व्यवस्थित करना
21	**vagaries** (Noun)	unpredictable changes • अनियमित बदलाव / उतार-चढ़ाव
22	**thriving** (Adjective)	flourishing • सफलतापूर्वक फलने-फूलने वाला

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EDITORIAL ANALYSIS & VOCABULARY LAB

ARTICLE: A death at IIT-Delhi and the many invisible struggles on campus

THE INDIAN EXPRESS · HIGHER EDUCATION & MENTAL HEALTH

EDITORIAL STANCE

URGENT AND REFLECTIVE

"serious and calling for change"

EXECUTIVE PERSPECTIVE

The author adopts an urgent and reflective tone to highlight the recurring tragedy of student suicides in elite educational institutions. By examining systemic alienation, intense competition, and the gap between academic admission and actual social integration, the piece argues that elite universities and parents must move beyond superficial remedies to foster truly supportive, empathetic environments.

EDITORIAL VOCABULARY · 12 WORDS

#	Word	Meaning	Memory Hook	Synonyms	Antonyms
01	**lurk** VERB NEGATIVE	घात लगाकर छिपे रहना / अनदेखा मौजूद होना Remain hidden or unsuspected, especially so as to wait in ambush or present a latent danger.	Sounds like 'lock' — something locked in the shadows waiting to emerge secretly.	• skulk • lie concealed • prowl	• manifest • surface • emerge
02	**proactive** ADJECTIVE POSITIVE	सक्रिय / अग्रसक्रिय Creating or controlling a situation rather than just responding to it after it has happened.	PRO (before) + ACTIVE — acting before an issue actually happens instead of reacting later.	• enterprising • forward-looking • pre-emptive	• reactive • passive • lethargic
03	**collision** NOUN NEGATIVE	टकराव / मतभेद A strong conflict or opposition between opposing ideas, cultures, or identities.	Think of two speeding vehicles colliding — here, disparate expectations violently crash.	• conflict • clash • friction	• harmony • concord • alignment
04	**burnout** NOUN NEGATIVE	अत्यधिक मानसिक या शारीरिक थकान A state of physical or mental exhaustion caused by prolonged stress or overwork.	A candle burning until all its wax is completely exhausted ('burned out').	• fatigue • depletion • prostration	• rejuvenation • vigour • vitality
05	**marginalised** ADJECTIVE NEGATIVE	हाशिए पर धकेले गए Treated as insignificant or placed in an excluded or powerless social position.	Pushed all the way to the 'margin' of the paper, away from the core text.	• disenfranchised • subjugated • disadvantaged	• privileged • empowered • mainstream
06	**consequential** ADJECTIVE NEUTRAL	अत्यधिक महत्वपूर्ण / गम्भीर परिणाम वाला Having important, significant, or grave results or consequences.	Something having deep 'consequences' is consequential.	• significant • momentous • weighty	• trivial • inconsequential • negligible
07	**probe** NOUN NEUTRAL	गहन जांच / अन्वेषण A thorough and formal inquiry or investigation into a matter or incident.	Think of a medical probe inserted deeply to inspect hidden issues.	• inquiry • investigation • scrutiny	• negligence • disregard • inattention
08	**premier** ADJECTIVE POSITIVE	अग्रणी / प्रमुख First in importance, order, position, or rank; leading.	Sounds like 'primary' — standing first in order of importance or quality.	• foremost • pre-eminent • paramount	• inferior • subordinate • minor
09	**contradiction** NOUN NEGATIVE	विरोधाभास A combination of statements, ideas, or situations that are opposed to one another.	CONTRA (opposite) + DICTION (saying) — stating or showing two incompatible things.	• paradox • inconsistency • incongruity	• consistency • congruity • harmony
10	**regulate** VERB NEUTRAL	नियंत्रित या व्यवस्थित करना To control, maintain, or adjust the rate, intensity, or emotional response properly.	Like a regulator controlling the flame or current to maintain balance.	• moderate • govern • modulate	• disorganise • deregulate • destabilise
11	**vagaries** NOUN NEGATIVE	अनियमित बदलाव / उतार-चढ़ाव Unexpected and inexplicable changes in a situation or in someone's behaviour.	Rhymes with 'vague' — unpredictable, vague changes that life throws unexpectedly.	• vicissitudes • fluctuations • whims	• predictability • constancy • stability
12	**thriving** ADJECTIVE POSITIVE	सफलतापूर्वक फलने-फूलने वाला Prospering, flourishing, or developing vigorously in health and well-being.	Think of 'striving' leading to successfully 'thriving'.	• flourishing • prospering • burgeoning	• languishing • deteriorating • withering

VOCAB LAB CONTINUED · A DEATH AT IIT-DELHI AND THE MANY INVISIBLE STRUGGLES ON CAMPUS · PART 02

ONE-WORD SUBSTITUTIONS · 3 TERMS

#	Word	Meaning	Memory Hook	Synonyms	Antonyms
01	**supernumerary** ADJECTIVE	अधिसंख्य / आवश्यकता या सामान्य संख्या से अधिक Present in excess of the normal or standard required number.	SUPER (above/beyond) + NUMERARY (numbers) = exceeding the standard count or quota.	• supplementary • surplus • additional	• essential • insufficient • deficit
02	**alienation** NOUN	अलगाव / बेगानापन The state of feeling isolated, estranged, or disconnected from an environment or society.	Feeling like an ALIEN among a group of familiar people.	• estrangement • detachment • disaffection	• belonging • inclusion • connectedness
03	**fortitude** NOUN	धैर्य / मानसिक दृढ़ता Courage and resolve in bearing pain or adversity with dignity and composure.	Related to 'fort' (strong military fortress) — displaying inner mental strength under attack.	• grit • resilience • endurance	• faintheartedness • cowardice • timidity

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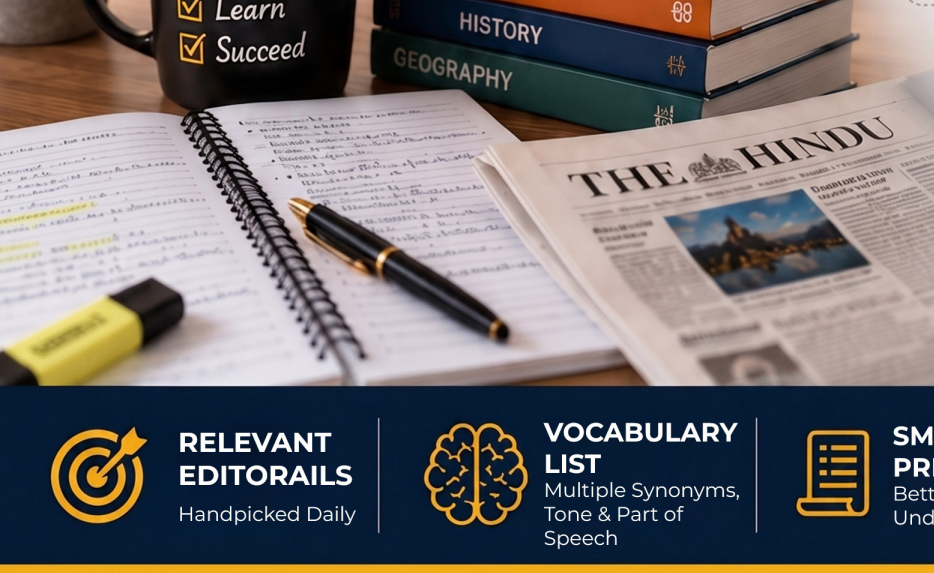

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